

**FICTIONAL TRAINING ARTIFACT — NOT FILED — NOT LEGAL
ADVICE**

UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT FOR THE EASTERN DISTRICT OF VIRGINIA
Richmond Division — Civil Action No. SYN-EDVA-25-CV-0412

**LEORA BENTON v. BLUE CEDAR
COMPLIANCE, INC.
Complaint and Jury Demand**

1. Leora Benton worked for Blue Cedar Compliance, Inc. as a senior compliance audit manager. She alleges that Blue Cedar selected her for a March 2025 reduction in force because she opposed sex-based assignment practices and participated in an EEOC proceeding.
2. Benton does not challenge Blue Cedar's decision to reduce payroll generally. She challenges the scoring changes, comparator exceptions, and explanations used to select her while retaining employees who performed materially overlapping audit work.
3. The action arises under Title VII. Benton seeks lost compensation, equitable relief, lawful damages, fees, costs, and a jury determination of disputed intent and causation.

Parties, jurisdiction, and venue

4. Benton resides in Virginia. Blue Cedar is incorporated in Virginia and maintains its principal office in Richmond. It provides internal-control audits and regulatory-readiness reviews to commercial clients.
5. Blue Cedar employed more than fifteen employees during every relevant pay period. Benton timely completed the administrative process described later in this complaint.
6. The Court has federal-question jurisdiction over the Title VII retaliation claim. Venue is alleged to be proper because Benton worked from Blue Cedar's Richmond office, the RIF calibration occurred there, and the termination decision was communicated there.
7. Benton began work in 2019. By 2024 she supervised multi-site audit teams, reviewed exception reports, and carried the title senior compliance audit manager. Her direct supervisor was Naomi Voss; operations vice president Draven Pike approved staffing reductions.

Work allocation and written opposition

8. In late 2024 Benton compared lead assignments for high-visibility field audits. She concluded that male managers were repeatedly given the lead credit used in promotion and performance scoring even when women performed the planning and remediation work.
9. On January 17, 2025, Benton wrote to Voss and human-resources director Mira Solis. She stated that the assignment pattern disadvantaged women, identified three project examples, requested a neutral allocation review, and asked Blue Cedar to preserve the assignment data.
10. Benton did not merely dispute her own workload. Her message said the pattern could constitute sex discrimination and asked the company to stop using lead-credit totals until it reviewed the allocation process.
11. Voss acknowledged the message and forwarded it to Solis. Solis opened an employee-relations file. Benton alleges those steps placed Blue Cedar on notice of protected opposition.

EEOC participation and employer notice

12. On February 3, 2025, Benton filed an EEOC charge. The charge repeated the assignment concern, identified her January 17 opposition, and stated that she feared the scoring process would be used to retaliate against her.
13. Blue Cedar received the EEOC notice packet on February 10. Solis acknowledged receipt that afternoon and routed the packet to outside counsel and Pike. A document-routing log records that Pike opened the packet on February 11.
14. Benton alleges participation in the EEOC process independently protected her. She further alleges Pike knew of both the charge and the underlying opposition before he approved the RIF selection.
15. Blue Cedar later denied that Pike reviewed the substance of the packet. Benton alleges the routing log, meeting calendar, and Pike's own notes support a contrary inference.

Reduction-in-force design

16. Finance director Sable Finch supplied a target of \$612,000 in annualized payroll savings. Blue Cedar opened a RIF workbook on February 14 and grouped managers by asserted functional overlap rather than eliminating an entire office or product line.
17. The written protocol assigned weighted points for audit completion, client continuity, credentials, cross-region availability, and role redundancy. It required the calibration team to record every manual adjustment and comparator exception.
18. Benton's first imported score was 84. Later versions reduced her client-continuity and availability points and applied a role-redundancy deduction. Blue Cedar retained Wynn, Ibarra, and Keene after applying credits or exceptions not reflected in Benton's row.
19. Benton alleges the savings target could have been met through combinations that did not include her position and that the final workbook did not mechanically select the lowest scores.

Comparator scoring and calibration

20. Tessa Wynn and Benton both managed regulated-client audits, reviewed remediation plans, and could assign field teams. Wynn received a continuity credit for a client transition scheduled to end in May 2025. Benton was denied the same credit for two transitions scheduled through June.
21. Omar Ibarra had a lower completion percentage but received an availability exception because he volunteered for travel. Benton's calendar showed more completed travel days, yet her score was reduced for a disputed refusal of one short-notice assignment.
22. Calvin Keene held a narrower title but performed overlapping review work. The calibration minutes stated that Keene supplied unique automation knowledge but recorded no transfer estimate for the scripts or Benton's overlapping review duties.
23. Benton alleges the comparator evidence matters not as a demand that employees be identical, but as evidence that criteria were applied selectively within the same RIF decision.

Termination and stated reasons

24. Pike approved Benton's selection on March 21. Blue Cedar terminated her on March 24, exactly six weeks after receiving the EEOC notice on February 10.
25. The termination letter described a budget-driven elimination of redundant management work. It did not cite performance, availability, or any disciplinary event.
26. In its April 18 EEOC response Blue Cedar emphasized salary savings and the ability to absorb Benton's projects. It also referred to her relative completion and availability profile, matters not identified in the March 24 termination letter.
27. Benton alleges those explanations are not interchangeable descriptions of one reason. She alleges the workbook versions, contemporaneous reviews, and records identified in the exhibit map permit a factfinder to decide whether Blue Cedar's stated grounds were its true grounds.

Count I — Title VII retaliation

28. Benton repeats paragraphs 1–27.
29. Benton's January 17 complaint opposed a practice she reasonably described as sex-based. Her February 3 charge and continued cooperation participated in a Title VII process.
30. Termination was materially adverse. Pike was the final decisionmaker and received the notice packet before the calibration decisions reflected in the final workbook.
31. Benton alleges causation through the six-week sequence, direct routing evidence, scoring changes, selective exceptions, positive performance records, and explanations that changed after the termination letter.
32. Benton alleges she would not have been selected absent retaliatory consideration. She does not rely on timing alone and identifies the emails, routing records, workbook versions, scorecards, and calibration notes listed in the exhibit map.

Pretext allegations and anticipated defenses

33. Blue Cedar is expected to identify a legitimate cost reduction. Benton alleges the existence of a real savings target does not resolve which employee was selected or why criteria changed.
34. Blue Cedar is expected to argue comparators had different portfolios. Benton alleges the RIF itself grouped them for calibration, measured overlapping functions, and made exceptions at the same decision level.
35. Blue Cedar is expected to deny Pike's knowledge. Benton alleges the routing log, his February 11 calendar attachment, and questions recorded in the March 4 minutes support knowledge.
36. Benton's merits theory rests on the contemporaneous scorecards, emails, metrics, routing log, and calibration records identified above, including the retained-manager exceptions and changes to her imported score.

Requested relief and jury demand

Benton requests:

- A. a declaration that Blue Cedar retaliated in violation of Title VII;
- B. back pay and benefits proved through admissible payroll evidence;
- C. reinstatement or appropriate front pay if reinstatement is impracticable;
- D. compensatory and other damages within applicable legal limits;
- E. prejudgment and post-judgment interest where authorized;
- F. fees, taxable costs, and further lawful equitable relief; and
- G. a jury trial on every triable issue.

The requested relief is not an admission that each category will be proved. Amounts and equitable feasibility remain for the finder of fact and the court under the governing law.

Complaint verification and exhibit map

Benton verifies that the factual allegations attributed to her are based on personal knowledge, records she reviewed, or information she presently believes to be true. Allegations about another person's intent are made on information and belief.

Exhibit map referenced by the complaint:

- January 17 opposition chain and follow-up messages;
- February 3 EEOC charge and February 10 notice routing;
- anti-retaliation policy and RIF scoring protocol;
- RIF workbook versions and comparator scorecards;
- calibration minutes, performance metrics, and headcount ledger; and
- the March 24 termination notice.

The listed materials are incorporated as the sources for the pleaded chronology. Production, authentication, admissibility, and the weight of each item remain governed by the applicable rules.